



THE RESORT & MARINE GROUP

Watersports Guest Experience

5 Things Resort Watersports Operations Get Wrong

Most resort watersports operations are running on autopilot. The kit was bought years ago, the briefings haven't changed since the centre opened, and the guest journey ends the moment someone steps off the water. Meanwhile, the operation carries real compliance obligations, untapped revenue potential, and a guest satisfaction ceiling that nobody has thought to raise.

We've assessed operations running everything from paddleboards and kayaks through to wing foiling, windsurfing, powered craft, and towed activities. The same five problems appear every time — regardless of the scale of the operation or the quality of the resort around it.

This is what we find. And what it's costing you.

01

The Fleet Doesn't Reflect What Guests Actually Want to Do

The equipment inventory at most resort watersports centres reflects what was available and affordable when the centre was set up — not what today's guests are looking for. Recreational kayaks and entry-level paddleboards make up the bulk of most fleets, while faster-growing disciplines are either absent or represented by a single piece of kit that nobody on staff knows how to teach.

What we typically find missing or inadequate:

- Wing foiling and windsurf equipment suited to the local wind conditions — not generic kit bought at procurement price.
- Performance SUP boards for guests who paddle at home and find resort kit frustratingly basic.
- Appropriate kids' equipment — scaled properly for age and weight, not adult kit handed to a ten-year-old.
- Towed activities infrastructure that meets current safety standards and integrates properly with the instruction team.
- Coaching aids: waterproof Bluetooth headsets for one-to-one instruction, action cameras for feedback sessions, photo and video capture for upsell.

The fix isn't replacing everything. It's identifying the additions that would meaningfully change what guests can do — and what they're willing to pay for.

02

Compliance Is Being Managed Reactively, Not Proactively

Every watersports operation carries legal and insurance obligations that vary by jurisdiction. What's required in the Mediterranean is different from the Caribbean, the Indian Ocean, or South-East Asia — and most resort operations are working from a compliance framework set up at opening and never reviewed since.

- Emergency Action Plans that exist on paper but haven't been rehearsed with current seasonal staff.
- Qualification requirements for guests that are either too restrictive (blocking bookings unnecessarily) or too permissive (creating liability).
- Safety equipment — life jackets, helmets, impact vests — that is either the wrong size range or past its serviceable life.
- Instructor certification that meets the resort's home market standards but not the standards of the country of operation.

Proactive compliance removes the friction that stops guests from booking. A clear qualification pathway that tells guests exactly what they can do — and how to access more — converts browsers into bookings.

03

The Briefing Creates Anxiety Instead of Anticipation

Safety briefings are non-negotiable. But the way most resort watersports briefings are delivered creates the wrong emotional state before a guest gets on the water. Too long, too focused on risk, delivered by a seasonal instructor who has given the same speech six times that morning.

Guests who feel nervous before they get on the water have a worse experience on the water — regardless of the instruction quality that follows. A well-designed briefing covers every compliance requirement, builds genuine confidence, and takes under four minutes. Most resort briefings take twelve and do none of those things. This applies equally across paddleboarding, kayaking, windsurf lessons, wing foiling tasters, and towed activities — each discipline has different anxiety triggers and needs a briefing designed around that.

04

There Is No Progression — and No Upsell

A guest who has a good first session will want to do something more on day three. If the only option is the same beginner session, you've lost a booking and missed the moment a casual guest becomes an enthusiast. Enthusiasts spend significantly more.

The revenue opportunities most operations leave on the table:

- Tiered session structure: beginner / improver / discipline-specific, each priced accordingly.
- Photo and video packages: action footage from SUP, foiling, or towed activities sells itself if someone offers it.

- Equipment upgrade options: guests who want better kit than the standard hire fleet will pay for the privilege.
- Private instruction: available at most operations but rarely sold — usually only booked when a guest specifically requests it.
- Intro sessions for new disciplines: a guest who's been paddleboarding for two days is a warm lead for a wing foiling taster. Nobody is asking them.

The post-session conversation — thirty seconds between instructor and guest as kit is handed back — is where all of this gets sold or doesn't. Most operations have no structure for this at all.

05

Nobody Is Measuring the Guest Experience on the Water

Resort satisfaction data is almost universally collected at property level. Watersports gets folded into a general activities score, which means problems are invisible until they show up in reviews. By the time a pattern is visible on TripAdvisor, it's been affecting real guests for months.

A simple post-session feedback mechanism — two questions via tablet or QR code at kit return — gives you data to act on before the damage is done. The two questions worth asking: "How would you rate your session?" and "Would you book another session during your stay?" The gap between those answers tells you whether your operation is converting experience into revenue. Most seasonal instructors have no visibility of how guests rate their sessions. Giving them that data changes behaviour.

Want to know how your operation scores on all five?

We spend 2-3 days at your property as a guest, assessing every aspect of your watersports operation — fleet, compliance, briefings, progression, and guest feedback. Full written report and follow-up call included.

Audit fee: £1,500 per property.

Travel and accommodation covered by the property.

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